THE FARM
AT OKEFENOKEE

Regenerative Farming

The Farm at Okefenokee

Building Healthy Soil, Land, and Communities

Project Narrative: Regenerative Silvopasture and Multi-Species Grazing Demonstration at The Farm at Okefenokee

The Farm at Okefenokee, a regenerative agriculture operation strategically located at the entrance to the Okefenokee National Wildlife Refuge near Folkston, Georgia, proposes a comprehensive project to transform 350 acres of recently harvested cutover pine land into a thriving, multi-functional silvopasture system. The pine trees were removed in 2024, leaving behind acidic soils with an average pH of approximately 5.0. This property, previously managed for intensive timber production, now presents an ideal opportunity to demonstrate how regenerative practices can rapidly restore degraded land, enhance ecosystem services, and deliver measurable benefits to soil, wildlife, livestock, and local communities.

This project aligns closely with the priorities of the USDA Natural Resources Conservation Service (NRCS), particularly through the **Regenerative Pilot Program** launched in December 2025. The program invests $700 million—$400 million via the Environmental Quality Incentives Program (EQIP) and $300 million via the Conservation Stewardship Program (CSP)—to support whole-farm regenerative agriculture initiatives focused on soil health, water management, biodiversity, and outcomes-based conservation. Key qualifying practices include prescribed grazing (Code 528), silvopasture establishment (Code 381), fencing (Code 382), watering facilities, forage and biomass planting, cover cropping, tree/shrub establishment, and related soil health and nutrient management activities.

By implementing adaptive multi-species rotational grazing, strategic tree and cover crop plantings, and essential infrastructure, the project will convert this challenging site into a model regenerative farm that sequesters carbon, improves soil organic matter and structure, enhances water infiltration and retention, increases biodiversity, and provides sustainable forage and habitat.

Site Conditions and Restoration Strategy

The 350-acre parcel exhibits typical challenges of post-harvest pine plantations in the southeastern Coastal Plain: compacted soils, low organic matter, limited native forage diversity, and acidity that limits nutrient cycling and plant establishment. Without active intervention, recovery is slow and often dominated by invasive brush or low-value species.

Through regenerative management, we will leverage the natural behaviors of heritage livestock to accelerate soil biology restoration. Multi-species grazing, combined with diverse cover crops and silvopasture tree plantings, will drive increases in soil organic matter, microbial activity, nutrient availability, and gradual pH buffering via manure inputs, root exudates, trampling, and residue decomposition. These practices are proven to build soil health even on acidic, degraded sites, while supporting resilient forage production.

Infrastructure Development

Effective rotational grazing and animal welfare require foundational infrastructure:

- **Fencing** — High-tensile perimeter fencing to fully enclose the 350 acres, followed by portable and permanent interior cross-fencing to create flexible paddocks. This enables precise control of graze periods and rest intervals, promoting even manure distribution and preventing overgrazing.
- **Water Systems** — Development of reliable, distributed water sources through drilled wells and strategically located small ponds. These will ensure clean water access across the property, minimize animal impact on sensitive areas near the refuge, and enhance drought resilience.

These components qualify under NRCS practices for livestock watering facilities and fencing.

Grazing and Silvopasture Implementation

We will employ adaptive, intensive rotational grazing using a diverse mix of heritage breeds selected for their hardiness, foraging efficiency, heat tolerance, parasite resistance, and compatibility with southeastern conditions:

- **Pineywoods cattle** — One of the oldest U.S. cattle breeds, descended from Spanish stock introduced in the 1500s; rugged, disease-resistant, and excellent on marginal forages.
- **Spanish goats** — Superior browsers that naturally control woody regrowth and brush while contributing to soil disturbance and fertility.
- **Barbados sheep** (Barbados Blackbelly) — Heat- and parasite-tolerant hair sheep that thrive in humid climates and provide versatile grazing/browsing.
- **Meishan pigs** — Docile, forage-efficient pigs that excel on pasture, utilize roughage, and enhance soil biology through rooting and nutrient cycling.

Animals will be rotated frequently—short, high-intensity graze periods followed by extended recovery—mimicking historic herd movements. Multi-species grazing maximizes forage utilization (different species target different plants), breaks parasite cycles, improves nutrient distribution, and accelerates soil regeneration.

To establish silvopasture (NRCS Code 381), we will plant site-appropriate native trees (e.g., longleaf pine, slash pine, oaks, or other regionally adapted species) in open configurations that maintain sufficient light for productive understory forages. Diverse cover crop and forage mixes—including grasses, legumes, and forbs—will be seeded to fix nitrogen, build soil cover, suppress weeds, and provide high-quality nutrition. This integrated system will yield multiple benefits: improved livestock performance, future timber or nut revenue streams, shade, carbon sequestration, and enhanced wildlife habitat compatible with the adjacent Okefenokee Refuge.

Educational and Demonstration Value

Located at the gateway to the Okefenokee National Wildlife Refuge—one of the most iconic wetlands in North America—The Farm at Okefenokee is ideally positioned as a public-facing demonstration site. Visitors, farmers, students, extension agents, and conservation groups will directly observe the transformation: visible improvements in forage quality, soil structure, water-holding capacity, and biodiversity. The farm will serve as a living classroom for silvopasture establishment and management on former cutover pine lands, offering workshops, field days, guided tours, and interpretive signage to promote broader adoption of regenerative practices across the Southeast.

Community Impact and Social Benefits

Once infrastructure is in place, we will partner with Trinity Rescue Mission in Jacksonville, Florida, to train women from their Women & Children's Center programs in rotational grazing, animal husbandry, farm operations, and regenerative land management. This hands-on training empowers participants with marketable agricultural skills, supports personal recovery and self-sufficiency, and creates pathways to employment.

Furthermore, 50% of the regeneratively raised heritage meat produced will be donated to feed hungry families and individuals in Folkston, Georgia, and Jacksonville, Florida—directly supporting Trinity Rescue Mission's food security efforts and addressing local hunger.

Monitoring and Evaluation

The project will include rigorous, ongoing measurement to document outcomes and contribute to scientific and practical knowledge:

- **Soil Health** — Annual and periodic testing of organic matter, pH, nutrients, microbial biomass, aggregate stability, infiltration rates, and carbon sequestration.
- **Ecological Indicators** — Forage biomass and diversity, plant and insect biodiversity, bird and wildlife usage, and habitat quality.
- **Livestock Performance** — Weight gains, reproduction, health, and forage utilization.
- **Human Benefits** — Collaboration with researchers or health partners to evaluate nutritional quality of the meat, as well as physical and psychological well-being of training participants and food recipients (e.g., surveys on energy, food security, and mental health).

Results will be shared through reports, presentations, educational events, and public outreach.

Broader Significance

This initiative will demonstrate that 350 acres of cutover pine land can be converted into a productive, resilient silvopasture system that improves soil health, conserves water, sequesters carbon, supports biodiversity, and generates economic and social value. As a regional example of post-forestry regeneration, it will inspire landowners across Georgia, Florida, and the Southeast to adopt similar practices.

By combining environmental restoration, education, workforce development, and direct community support, The Farm at Okefenokee embodies holistic regenerative agriculture that benefits people, animals, land, and ecosystems.

We respectfully request NRCS consideration under the Regenerative Pilot Program (via EQIP and/or CSP) and stand ready to collaborate with agency staff, technical service providers, and partners to achieve outstanding outcomes. This project can serve as a flagship demonstration of what is possible when regenerative principles are applied to challenging landscapes near ecologically sensitive areas.

Thank you for your consideration.